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Response to Mishra's "Flailing States"

Pankaj Mishra's essay about the varying responses to COVID-19 by the countries of the world raises several important questions. Arguably, the author's main purpose is to explain the failure of world superpowers to adequately handle the issues brought about by the virus. Mishra specifically talks about the United States and the United Kingdom, pointing out the fact that they have been hit the hardest by the virus despite their historical status as superpowers which were examples of successful economic and cultural models. The author mentions how the two nations have ruinously failed the true test of a good government, which is, according to Alexander Hamilton, its "aptitude and tendency to produce a good administration" (Mishra 1). This essay will further explore the ideas in Mishra's writing, discuss its implications regarding national ideologies, and ideally provide a richer understanding of the subject matter.

Toward the beginning of the essay, Mishra writes that the current governments in the US and UK gained power during the crisis by "fomenting hatred of experts and expertise" (Mishra 2). This is to say that those in power, Donald Trump and Boris Johnson, often appointed people close to themselves rather than experts in the field, leading to a great deal of mistrust, an innumerable quantity of blunders, and divisive conspiracy theories. These factors also created a strong sense of anger among millions of people, which in turn led to uprisings and insurrections in protest to the inequities in the American system. The United Kingdom, on the other hand, splintered because of the exposition of their misfounded "national identity propped up by fantasies of empire" (Mishra 3). By establishing these arguments, Mishra argues that the histories of the two nations have positioned them in such a way that the failure to properly respond to the coronavirus crisis was inevitable. He writes about the "narcissistic intellectual habits" which have created a certain sense of invulnerability and overconfidence in the United States and the United Kingdom - the belief that one's own country is the greatest and that it will never be defeated. This ideology pervades the culture of the two nations, many of its people being conditioned early in life to "pledge allegiance to the flag", or at the very least to be extremely loyal to the country, creating the aforementioned sense of overconfidence. More specifically, this overconfidence comes from the countries' histories of success, having recently claimed victory in the two World Wars, the Cold War, and several other conflicts since. The doctrine of manifest destiny should also be mentioned, the belief that it is the purpose of the United States to expand its borders and strengthen itself, something believed to be justified and inevitable. In this way, Mishra points out that the ideologies of the world superpowers were fundamentally flawed and bound to be exposed by the advent of the coronavirus. The countries did not take the virus

seriously enough because of their intrinsic overconfidence and stubbornness, and have thus paid the extreme consequences.

Mishra continues his essay by comparing the US and UK ideologies to the ideologies of other nations. He mentions the approaches of Germany, South Korea, Vietnam, and others, explaining how they have fought back against the virus significantly more effectively. The author goes into greater detail about Germany's history and how it has contributed to their success against COVID-19.

Source Text:

<https://www.lrb.co.uk/the-paper/v42/n14/pankaj-mishra/flailing-states>